

[Return to Search](#)

Nyoro kinship

Author(S): Beattie, John

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 338

Culture (OWC): [Banyoro \(FK11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1951-1955

Coverage Date: 1951-1955

Place Coverage: Western Province, Uganda

Section Title(S): IV

It will be noted from the diagram that the siblings of a grandfather are 'grandfathers' (*baisenkuru*) without regard to sex, and that the siblings of a grandmother are 'grandmothers' (*banyinenkuru*) without regard to sex. It should cause us no surprise that a man may be a 'grandmother' and a woman a 'grandfather'. We have seen that a person's father's sister is not a mother but a kind of father, and a person's mother's brother is not a father but a kind of mother. To that person's children, therefore, the father's sister of either parent is a 'grandfather', since she is that parent's (female) father, and the mother's brother of either parent is a 'grandmother', since he is that parent's (male) mother. It could not consistently be otherwise in the system which I have described, where membership of one or other of the parental agnatic units is more important than difference of sex as a criterion for the terminological differentiation of kin.

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

603
[Grandparents And Grandchildren](#)

In general Nyoro practice exemplifies what Radcliffe-Brown termed the 'merging of alternate generations'.¹ The relations between grandparents and grandchildren are friendly and intimate, contrasting strongly with the father-child relationship. It is permissible for a grandchild to touch his grandfather's hair or beard, which he may not do in the case of his father. A boy may joke familiarly with his grandparents, and they are said to spoil and over-feed their grandchildren and treat them indulgently. An informant told me that, when he was a boy of about seven, he played a trick on his grandfather by bringing him, instead of the roasted coffee berries he expected, a handful of balls of goat dung picked up in the compound. His grandfather did not discover the trick until he had put one in his mouth. It would be unthinkable to play such a trick on one's father: in the case quoted the father was only prevented from giving his son a sound beating by the intervention of the grandfather, who was more

121
[Theoretical Orientation](#)

522
[Humor](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

602

amused than angry. Banyoro sometimes say that a grandfather is 'like a brother'. Consistently with this, a youth may jokingly call his grandfather's wives his wives. This terminological usage need not always have a primarily sexual reference (though it does sometimes, e.g. in the case of a brother's wives). If a Munyoro is asked why he says that a grandfather's wife is 'like his own wife', he usually replies by referring [339](#) either to the friendliness and informality of his relationship with her, or to the fact that she is generally happy to prepare him a meal.¹

Kin Relationships

603
Grandparents And
Grandchildren

¹ This 'merging' is not thought of as occurring at the great-grandparent—great-grandchild level. A man calls his great-grandchild *katarabanyuma* (literally 'that which may not pass behind one's back'), and a great-grandchild is subject to certain prohibitions in his relations with his great-grandfather, just as a son is in relation to his father. Thus, in conformity with Radcliffe-Brown's principle, ego is 'merged' with his grandfather, ego's father with *his* grandfather.

¹ Male Banyoro often refer to the preparation (where a relationship to a woman is concerned) or sharing (where a relationship to a man is concerned) of food when they wish to indicate that there is, or should be, close and friendly attachment between kinsfolk.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: [✉ hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs: [✉ hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)